

Robots

When people first imagined robots, they thought of mechanical humans with slow, jerky movements and slow thought. In fact, the first effective robots did repetitive, mindless work on factory production lines. However, with the introduction of AI (artificial intelligence), robots have shown that they can outsmart us. Who knows where robotic technology might take us?

WOW!

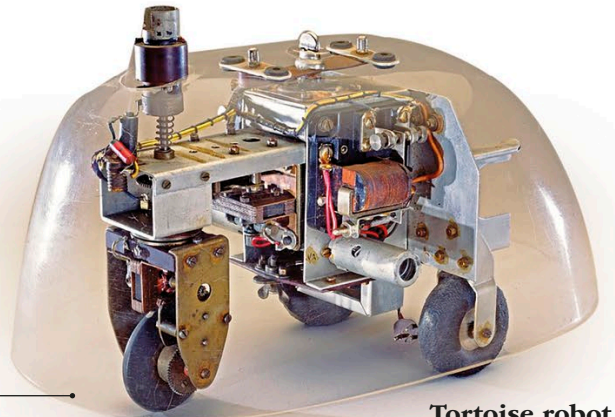
The term “robot” was invented by Czech author Karel Capek, from his 1920 play *R.U.R.* (*Rossum’s Universal Robots*).

Baxter, created by Rethink Robotics, 2012—the first robot to work alongside humans on a production line

TORTOISE ROBOTS

The first autonomous (self-controlling) robots were Elmer and Elsie, created by the American-born scientist William Grey Walter of the Burden Neurological Institute, UK, in 1948–1949. These “tortoise robots” could find their way to a recharging point when low on power.

Shell sensed when robot bumped into objects so it could move around them



Tortoise robot, c. 1950

INDUSTRIAL ROBOTS

Americans George Devol and Joe Engelberger designed and marketed the first programmable robot arm, called Unimate, and sold it to General Motors in 1960. It was used to lift hot pieces of metal from a die-casting machine and stack them. From then, robotics quickly transformed the automotive industry.

Baxter can do a variety of tasks, such as packing boxes.

